

— EDITION 04

PREGAME: MEXICO VS SOUTH AFRICA — THE OPENER

*16 years after Tshabalala, the rematch
opens a World Cup.*

A 7-part breakdown

SWIPE ►►►

0101 / 07

| MEXICO V SOUTH AFRICA.

Group A · Estadio Azteca, Mexico City ·
Thursday June 11 · 3:00 PM ET. *The Azteca
becomes the first stadium ever to open three
World Cups — 1970, 1986, 2026.*

0202 / 07

| WE HAVE BEEN HERE BEFORE.

11 June 2010, Soccer City. Tshabalala's screamer opened Africa's first World Cup. Rafael Márquez answered late. 1-1. *Sixteen years to the day, the fixture flips continents.*

0303 / 07

| THE FORM GAP.

Mexico arrive unbeaten in eight in 2026 — Ghana 2-0, Australia 1-0, Serbia 5-1. South Africa's send-off: 0-0 with Nicaragua, 1-1 with Jamaica. *On paper, one-way. Openers don't read paper.*

0404 / 07

| THE HOME TALISMAN.

Raúl Jiménez. 44 goals for Mexico — second only to Borgetti — and the man who equalised against the USA in the 2025 Gold Cup final. *El Lobo leads the line at the Azteca.*

0505 / 07

| THE WALL IN HIS WAY.

Ronwen Williams — captain, goalkeeper, the man who saved four penalties in one AFCON shootout. *If Bafana Bafana survive the opening storm, it starts with him.*

0606 / 07

HOSTS ALMOST NEVER LOSE OPENERS.

Only once has a World Cup host lost its opening match — Qatar in 2022. Mexico have never lost a World Cup opener they hosted (1970, 1986). *Streaks exist to be tested.*

0707 / 07

| YOUR CALL. SAVE THIS BRIEF.

Mexico's pace against the AFCON's best keeper, 16 years of history, and a stadium built for opening nights. *Drop your scoreline in the comments — we archive the verdicts at full time.*

— THE TAKEAWAY

WHO TAKES THE **OPENER?**

Scoreline in the comments — and follow @fifa.archv for the daily tournament archive.